Thus these wider narratives of democratization can reveal the contrasting frameworks through which Muslim–Buddhist tensions are understood.

Yet another crucial dimension illuminated through this study was the contests *within* the democracy movement. The *moral* emphasis on unity and benevolence is not universally accepted and, in fact, its core tenets are deeply challenged by an alternate narrative that highlights the need for cultural reform away from norms of hierarchy. For proponents of this *equality* narrative, the emphasis on benevolent leadership and unity is seen to be deeply problematic. Some perceive an inherent tendency toward abuse of power in Bamar culture and religion. These cultural traits emphasize unity and majority protection and yet consistently allow dictatorial leaders to take control. And this problem is not only considered to lie at the national level of politics but throughout society — in local aid organizations, religious organizations, and even in the family. In order to progress toward genuine democratization, proponents of this *equality* narrative suggest the core elements of the *moral* narrative of democratization need to be questioned. When asked in an interview about the main challenge to Myanmar's democratization, U Tun Kyi, an activist organization leader, said:

> It's the culture … the hierarchy and religious teaching. The social teaching and religious teaching listened with no criticism … these are key challenges for the practice of the democracy (Interview 9, 2013 English/Burmese).

In the context of communal violence and Muslim–Buddhist tensions, some activists believe there has been an unfortunate reinforcement of the dominant *moral* narrative of democratization. And this has served to distract from the core issue of reforming Myanmar's wider political culture — and especially the role of the military in governance. At its core, the rise in communal violence is seen to represent yet another failure of the military-dominated government. Or even further, some see anti-Muslim sentiments as having been actively fostered by elements in the government in order to divide the opposition. As one activist argued, "the fear is being instilled by the regime … I think the regime is taking advantage of this fear and are stoking this fear" (Interview 34, 2014 English).

Whatever the case, Bamar activists who are proponents of this narrative suggest that genuine democratization will entail a wholesale cultural reform and a shift toward greater relational equality — and that the dominant Bamar reactions to the issue of communal violence are a sign of the very